

THE LIZARD

Lacerta



SIZE RANKING 68

BRIGHTEST STAR
Alpha (α) 3.8GENITIVE
Lacertae

ABBREVIATION Lac

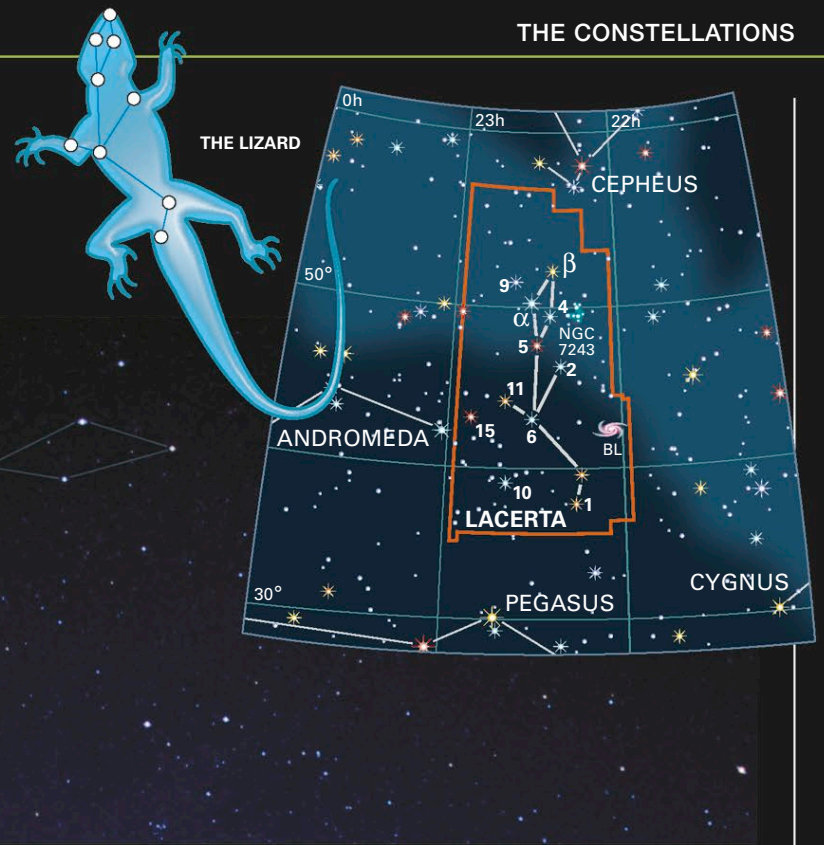
HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.
September–OctoberFULLY VISIBLE
90°N–33°S

Lacerta consists of a zigzag of faint stars in the northern sky, squeezed between Andromeda and Cygnus like a lizard between rocks. It is one of the seven constellations invented by Johannes Hevelius (see p.384) during the late 17th century.

This constellation contains no objects of note for amateur astronomers, although BL Lacertae (see p.325), which was once thought

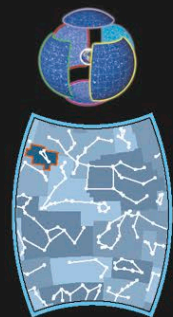
to be a peculiar 14th-magnitude variable star, has given its name to a class of galaxies with active nuclei called BL Lac objects or “blazars.”

A BL Lac object is a type of quasar that shoots jets of gas from its center directly toward the Earth. Because we see these jets of gas head-on, these BL Lac objects tend to look starlike.



THE TRIANGLE

Triangulum



SIZE RANKING 78

BRIGHTEST STAR
Beta (β) 3.0

GENITIVE Trianguli

ABBREVIATION Tri

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.
November–DecemberFULLY VISIBLE
90°N–52°S

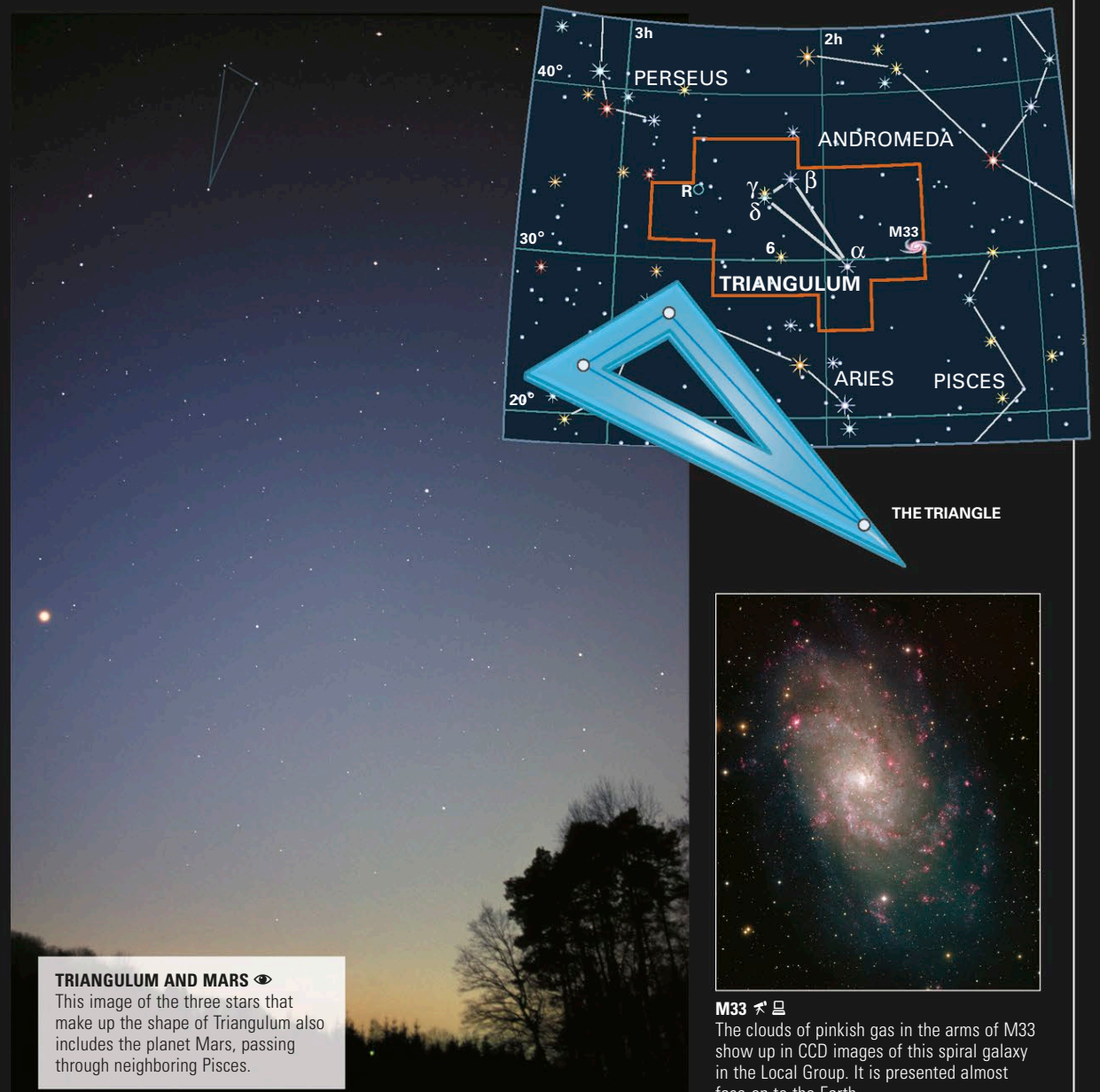
This small northern constellation is to be found lying between Andromeda and Aries. It consists of little more than a triangle of three stars. Triangulum is one of the constellations known to the ancient Greeks, who visualized it as the Nile delta or the island of Sicily.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Triangulum contains the third-largest member of our Local Group of galaxies, M33 or the Triangulum Galaxy (see p.311). In physical terms, M33 is about one-third the size of the Andromeda Galaxy, or M31 (see pp.312–313), and is much fainter.

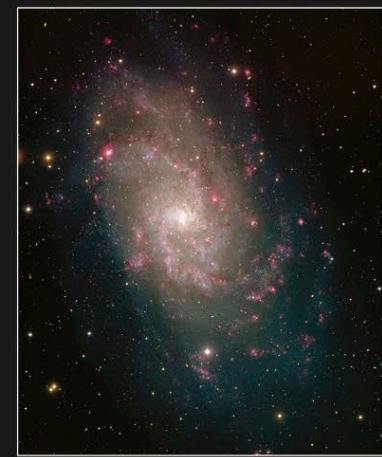
The spiral galaxy M33 appears as a large pale patch of sky. It is similar in size to a full moon, when viewed through binoculars or a small telescope on a dark, clear night. To see the spiral arms, a large telescope is needed. M33 looks like a starfish on long-exposure photographs.

There is little else of note in the constellation apart from 6 Trianguli. This yellow star has a magnitude of 5.2 and has a 7th-magnitude companion that can be detected through a small telescope.



TRIANGULUM AND MARS

This image of the three stars that make up the shape of Triangulum also includes the planet Mars, passing through neighboring Pisces.



M33

The clouds of pinkish gas in the arms of M33 show up in CCD images of this spiral galaxy in the Local Group. It is presented almost face-on to the Earth.